

WOMEN AND CHILD DEVELOPMENT

Krishna Tirath 55



A first-time Union minister, Tirath was a minister in the Delhi government. However, social engineering rather than performance seems to have got her into Manmohan Singh's Cabinet.

***THE FUNDS** Rs 6,919 crore in 2008-09 to Rs 7,428 crore now.

THE AGENDA Has spoken more about rights of women on TV reality shows than come up with any out-of-the-box ideas. Is working on the UPA's promised National Mission for Women's Empowerment.

LABOUR AND EMPLOYMENT

M. Kharge 59



A first time MP but a nine-time state assembly winner, the blunt Kharge is a reluctant entrant into Central politics. A lawyer and a trade union leader, he is more visible touring flood-hit Karnataka than his ministry.

***THE FUNDS** Rs 2,481 crore in 2008-09 to Rs 2,443 crore now.

THE AGENDA Cuts an impressive figure at international labour conferences. Back home, knows what is to be done but is figuring out the delivery system. Focusing on labour reforms and a way to implement the ban on child labour.

DEVELOPMENT OF NORTH EASTERN REGION

B.K. Handique 74



Wears Ray-Bans, sharp jackets and an earnest look. A keen tennis player, he thinks that infrastructure, sports and music are the way to integrate the North-east with the rest of India.

***THE FUNDS** Rs 1,473 crore (including state plans) in 2008-09 to Rs 1,475 crore now.

THE AGENDA Has learnt the Rahul mantra and is focusing on the youth. Has even located a youth icon for the North-east, Dr T. Ao, India's first Olympic footballer and named a tournament after him. Set up trouble-shooting cells for North-eastern students in Delhi.

the schemes for women. And, of course, there is a proposal to call these Rajiv Kendras.

The Labour Ministry has been given to a former trade union activist and a labour lawyer, the burly Kharge. A key player in the Karnataka stage, he is more visible touring the flood-hit areas of his state than at Shram Shakti Bhavan. Soon after he took office, he addressed the International Labour Conference in Geneva and made an impressive presentation of the India story as a panacea for recession: the need for employment generation (NREGA), social protection (the proposed smart card-based rural health insurance) and skill upgradation. The tragedy is that back home two of these exist as concept papers while the third has run into logistical problems. Kharge's lament is that labour laws do not have the same kind of force enjoyed by other statutes like the Criminal Procedure Code. "Whatever is implemented we do it with folded hands," he told the media once. Once again it is the system that is to be blamed.

The tribal affairs minister too is complaining of tied hands. He has asked the prime minister for more legislative and financial powers. As the problem of Naxalism grows, so does the importance of his ministry as the tribal belt is the most vulnerable. Manmohan realises this. That's why he asked Bhuria to ensure the tribals are not left out of the development story. The minister is rushing to implement the Forests Rights Act by the end of the year (a somewhat unrealistic deadline announced in Pratibha Patil's address to Parliament) even though various tribal groups have complained that they have been left out of land allotment.

Now the PMO has asked for report cards with vision and mission statements. On paper, all these ministers have got their homework done. Leading the paper tiger brigade is Selja who claims that she has an 'in principle' approval by the Planning Commission for the Rajiv Awas Yojana scheme to give property rights to urban slum dwellers. Incidentally, the BJP claims this is just a rehash of its Valmiki Ambedkar Awas Yojana announced in 2001 by the NDA to provide 50 per cent subsidised housing for the poor. Bhuria is still working on the contours of a National Tribal Policy, Tirath on the Women Empowerment Mission, while Wasnik has handed the Planning Commission his note on the Prime Minister's Adarsh Gram Yojana, a plan for integrated development for villages with more than 50 per cent Dalit population.

It is now six months since UPA Part Two took office. An impressive list of projects has been announced, a large chunk of funds have been released. The prime minister has set deadlines while Sonia and her son ad lib to the socially correct causes. The semantics are clear; this is a government with a conscience. Yet their chosen conscience keepers still have to get their act together. Otherwise as Mani Shankar Aiyar says, "We will have a globalisation of prosperity and a localisation of poverty." And that's no way to win elections. ■